

Managing Projects to Achieve Results

Lesson 1





Study Information and Tips



This Study Text replicates the video content for the lesson



Supplementary knowledge can also be found in the information sheets and text boxes that accompany the videos, as well as in the resources in the Insights section



Activities to help you consolidate your knowledge are deliberately delivered through practice questions and exercises found in the Test and Apply sections on the VLE. These help you to further build on your knowledge and apply the learning in a way that supports your assessment



You can use this Study Text to test your understanding of the learning content at the end of each lesson. It may also be helpful to refer to it when preparing for your assessments



We recommend that you also produce your own notes in addition to the Study Text. Research has shown that handwritten notes can be very effective for learning retention



If you decide to print this Study Text, set the layout to print 4 or 6 slides per page to save on paper and ink



The Fundamentals of Project Management

**What Defines a
Project**

The Project Life Cycle



What Defines a Project

If you work in business, chances are you have already taken part in a project. Projects are so common, and the word itself is so familiar, it's easy to forget the process has many components.

According to the Project Management Institute:

'A project is **temporary** in that it has a defined beginning and end in time, and therefore defined scope and resources. A project is **unique** in that it is not a routine operation, but a **specific** set of operations designed to accomplish a singular goal. A project team often includes people who don't usually work together – sometimes from different organizations and across multiple geographies.'

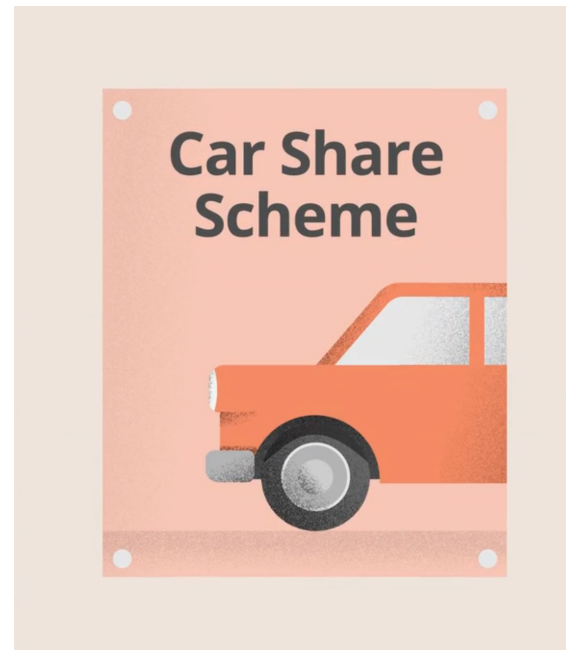
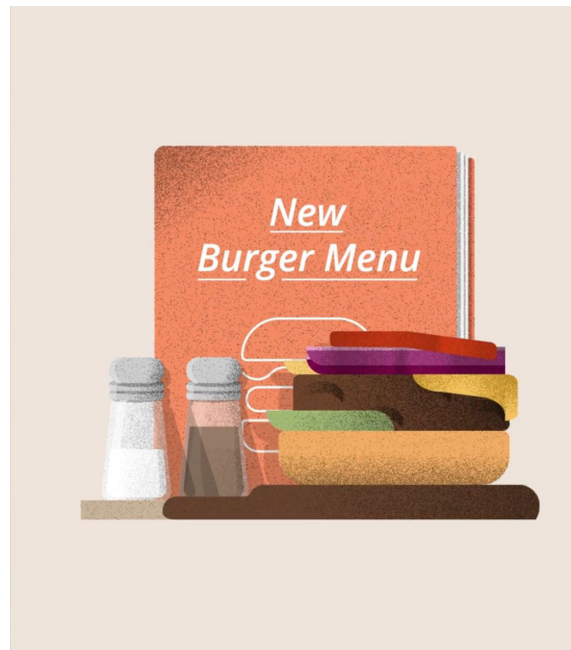
So, a project is time-bound, non-routine, goal-focused, and usually has fixed resources. It is almost always collaborative.





When Does a Project Begin?

A project typically begins when an organisation recognises a need for change. The change might require a significant undertaking, such as development of a new product line, or a smaller venture, such as setting up an office car-share scheme.

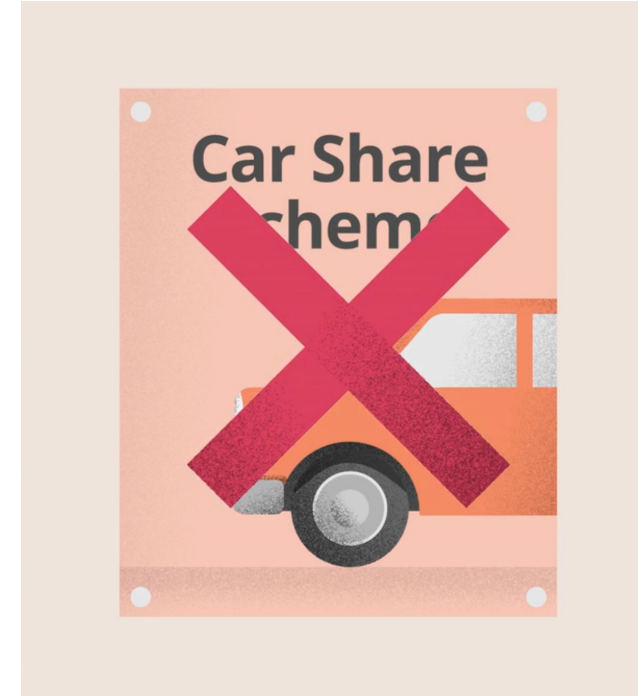




When Does a Project Begin? (cont.)

All projects start as ideas, but not all ideas become projects. Scoping out the car-share proposal, you might encounter so many practical difficulties – distance between employees, let's say, or variable working hours – that you might decide it's not worth proceeding.

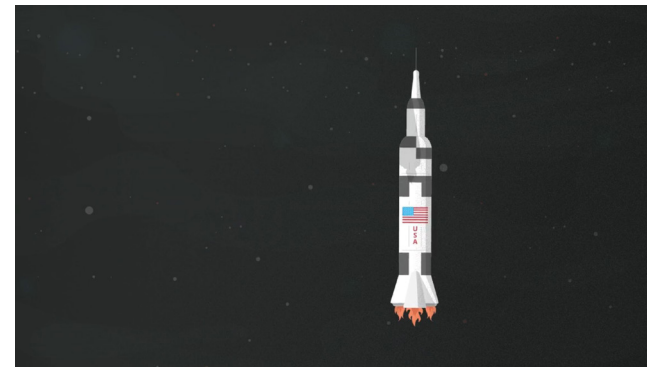
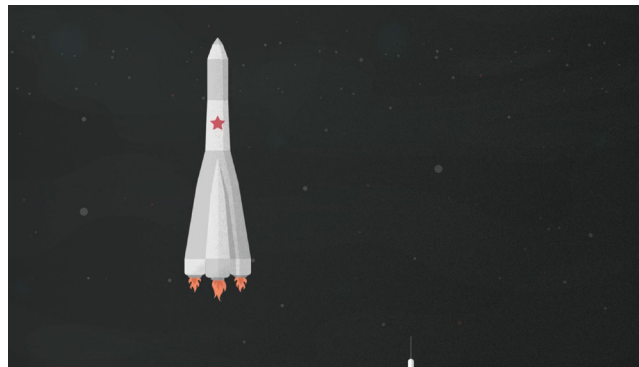
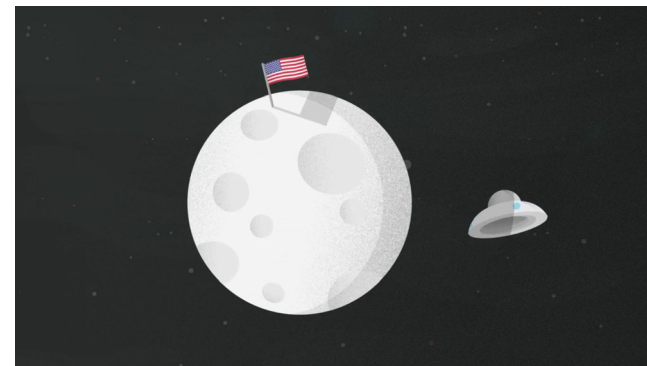
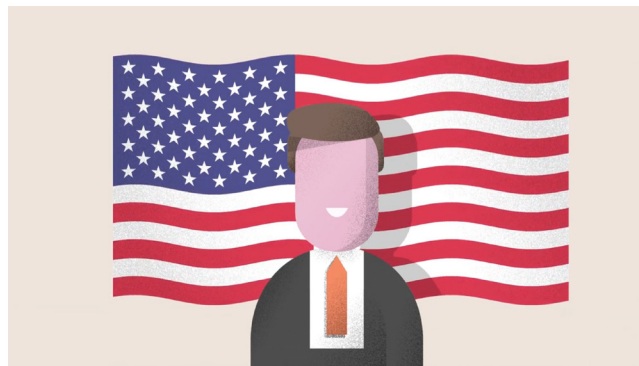
However, there is danger in reaching a conclusion too quickly – sometimes practical difficulties can be overcome during the course of the project itself. The important point is to give a number of ideas room to develop, and then pick the one that will deliver the most impact.





The Kennedy Space Race

For example, when President Kennedy announced in 1962 that the US planned to put a man on the moon within a decade, various other possibilities for 'catching up with the Soviets in space' had already been explored.

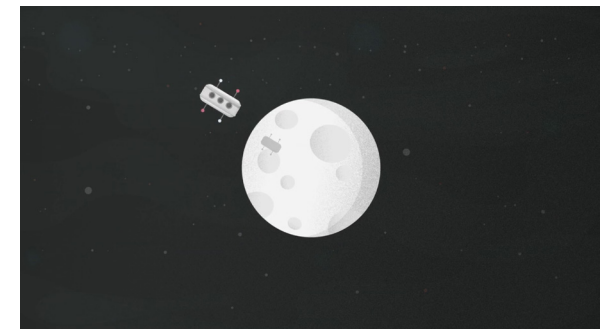
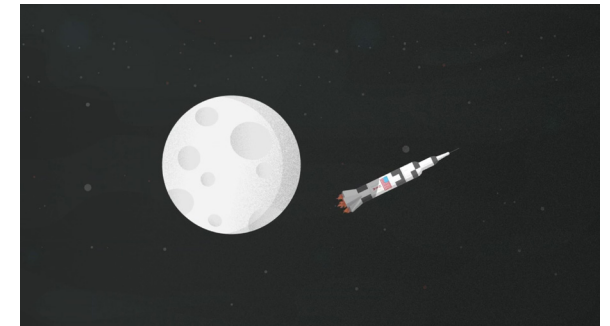
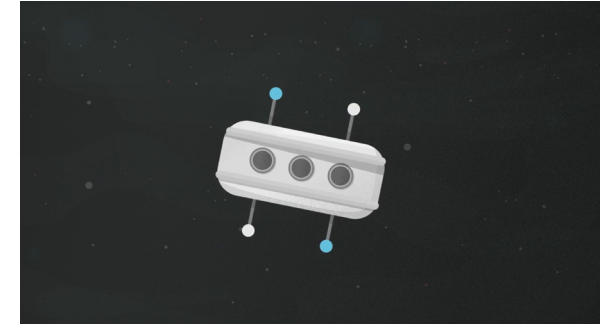




The Kennedy Space Race (cont.)

Kennedy had asked: 'Do we have a chance of beating the Soviets by putting a laboratory in space, by a trip around the moon, or by a rocket to go to the moon and back? Is there any other space program that promises dramatic results in which we could win?'

In other words, the first stage of the Apollo programme was not building, or even designing a rocket – it was deciding which option offered the best balance between dramatic results and feasibility.





The Project Manager

Once an idea gathers enough support to officially become a project, a project manager is appointed to guide it toward its goal.

A project manager needs to identify resources and ensure they are used effectively to achieve the project's objectives. This requires specific skills and techniques. In fact, project management is a profession in its own right – in the UK, it's represented by the Association for Project Management, or APM.

Keep in mind that managing a project is about managing human needs. Managers can run into problems when they get overly involved with targets and specifications while losing sight of the attitudes and feelings of the people affected by the project. This is a key reason why project management requires a wide range of skills, and why this unit covers a broad spread of topics.

It is why multi-million pound, multi-stage projects require specialists, either employed directly by the organisation or hired on a contract basis for the duration of the project.



The Project Life Cycle

A project takes shape outside the everyday routine of an organisation. It's also time-bound; all projects end eventually, even if that endpoint is years later.

The duration of the project is known as the project life cycle, and within that life cycle many activities need to take place.

There is disagreement on the exact number of phases a project lifecycle should contain, but in this lesson we are going to break it down into five parts.





Conception and Initiation Phase

At the start of any project, there is a “conception and initiation phase”. It usually begins with a business case – researching whether the project is feasible, and what impact it might have on the business. If needed, feasibility testing may also be done at this stage.

By the end of the phase there should be clarity about:

- What deliverables must be generated
- How work should be accomplished and who needs to be involved
- How to control and approve each phase

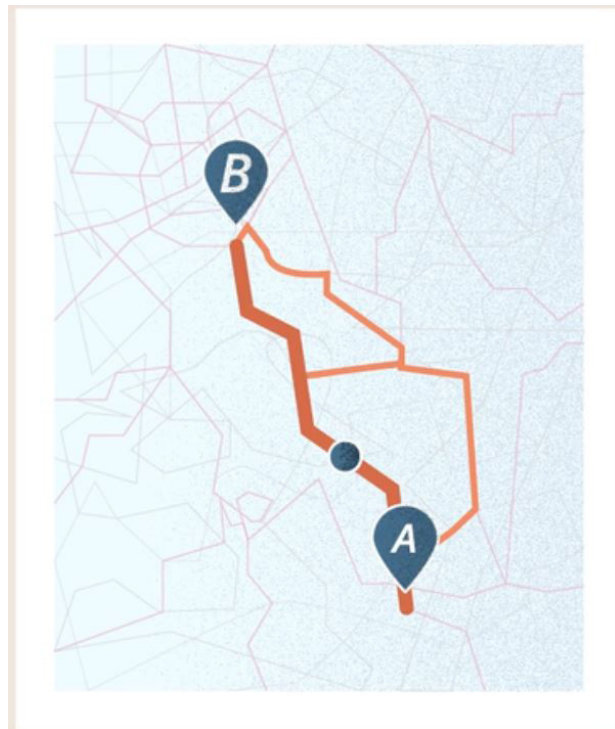
The document that records this information is known as the “project charter”.





Definition and Planning Phase

In the second phase of project management the “definition and planning phase” the focus is on developing a roadmap that the whole team will follow. This phase typically begins with setting more specific goals, preferably **SMART** goals. **This acronym stands for:**



- S** - *Specific:* Detailing the who, what, where, when and why of the project
- M** - *Measurable:* Defining criteria to evaluate the success of a goal
- A** - *Attainable:* Having a clear idea of what is required to reach the goal
- R** - *Realistic:* Setting goals that you know can be achieved
- T** - *Time-related:* Setting a timeframe for their achievement



Project Management Documents

As part of this phase the project manager produces a range of documents, including:

- A Scope Statement. This defines the business need, benefits of the project, objectives, deliverables, and key milestones. While it may change during the project, no changes should be made without the approval of the project manager.
- A Work Breakdown Schedule. This is a visual representation that breaks down the work commitments into manageable sections.
- Milestones. These are high-level targets that need to be met throughout the project.



Scope Statement



Work Breakdown Schedule



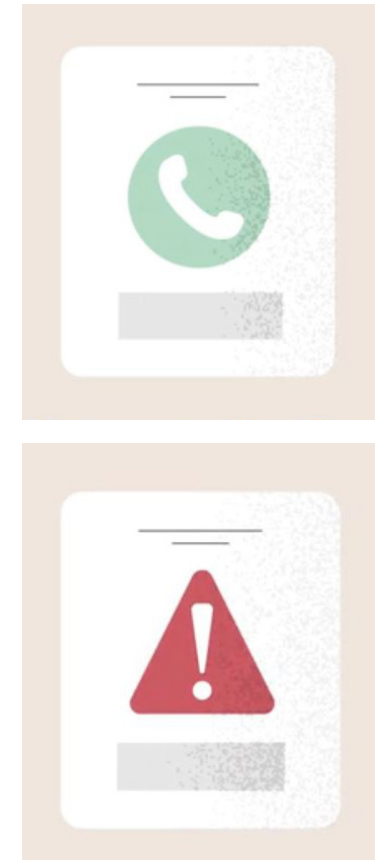
Milestones



Project Management Documents (cont.)

- Communication Plan. This is used to develop the messaging around the project, and schedule feedback sessions with team members and stakeholders based on milestones and deliverables.
- Risk Management Plan, which should identify all foreseeable risks. Common risks include unrealistic time and cost estimates, negative outcomes of customer review cycles, budget cuts, changing requirements, and lack of committed resources.

Knowing what to put in all these documents before the project starts is difficult. In fact, one approach to planning is known as progressive elaboration. This is a process of continuously improving and detailing a plan as more specific information becomes available. The more information is gathered, the more accurate the plan can become.





The Execution Stage

Now that we have planned our project in detail, we can move on to our third project phase, the execution stage. This is where deliverables are developed and completed. It's also the heart of the project – meetings, status reports and performance reports may take place regularly at this time. In fact, most of the resources and effort on a project are spent during the execution phase.



The Performance and Monitoring Phase and The Closure Phase

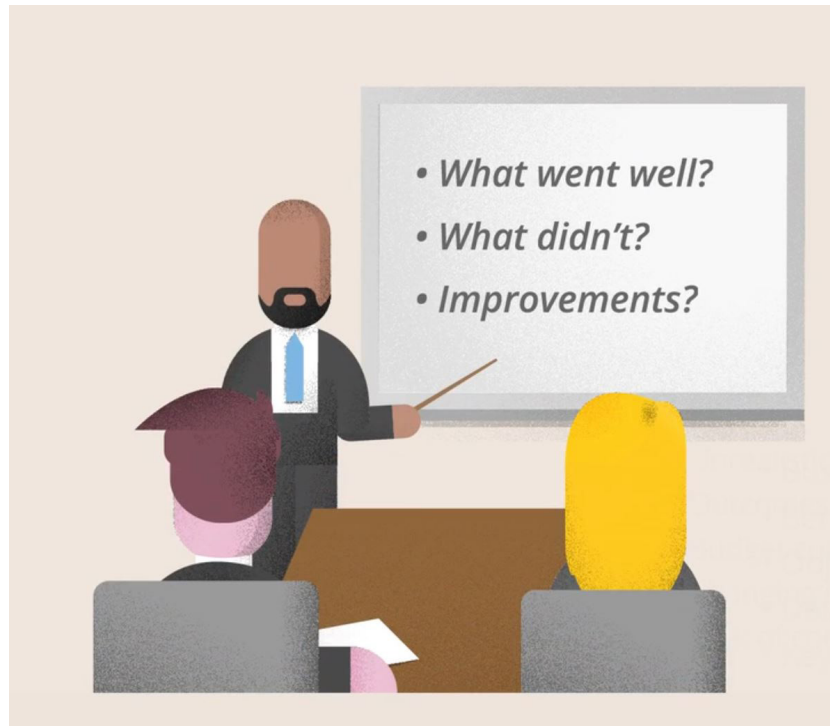
The project performance and monitoring phase is – as you might expect – the process of checking that everything is happening in alignment with the project management plan. Project managers will use key performance indicators – KPIs – to determine if the project is on track. We will look at this process in more detail later in the unit.

The closure phase marks the completion of a project, but it's more eventful than the name suggests.



The Post Mortem

When the project comes to a close, a project manager will often hold a meeting – sometimes referred to as a post-mortem – to evaluate what went well, what didn't and to identify potential improvements.



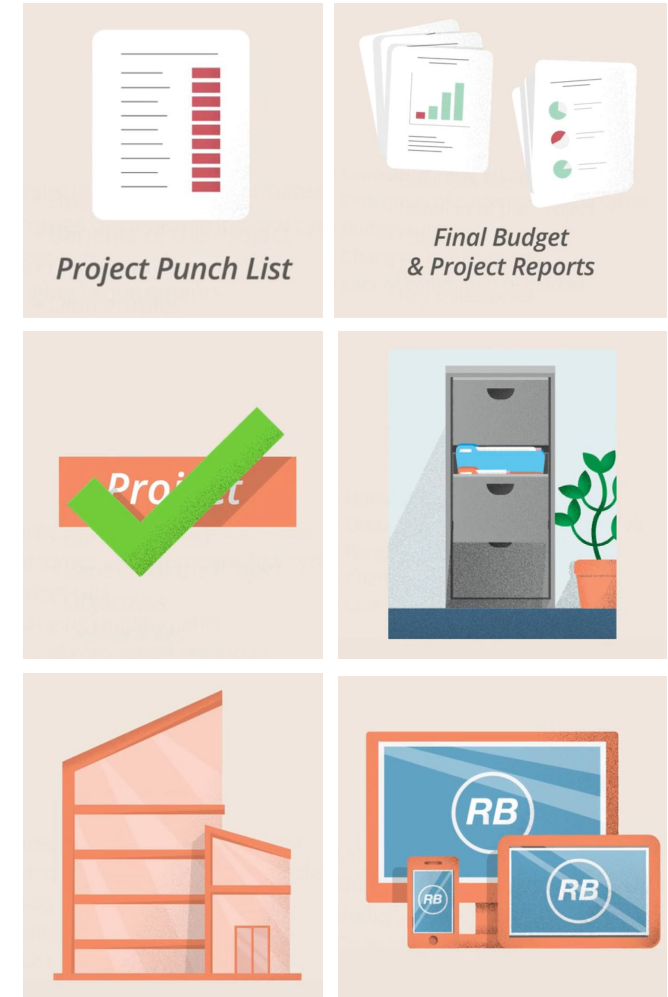


The Post Mortem (cont.)

A document known as a 'project punch list' will show uncompleted items. These can become the basis of a new plan, perhaps for the next version of the product. Sometimes these meetings are held after each deliverable, allowing the project to learn from its mistakes in real time.

There are still a few tasks to complete in the closure phase. Final budget and project reports need to be compiled. The project manager then needs to collate all documents and deliverables and store them in a single place.

At the successful completion of a project, something exists that didn't exist before. It may be tangible, such as a new building, or intangible, such as increased market awareness of a brand.





Projects in Cycles and in Isolation

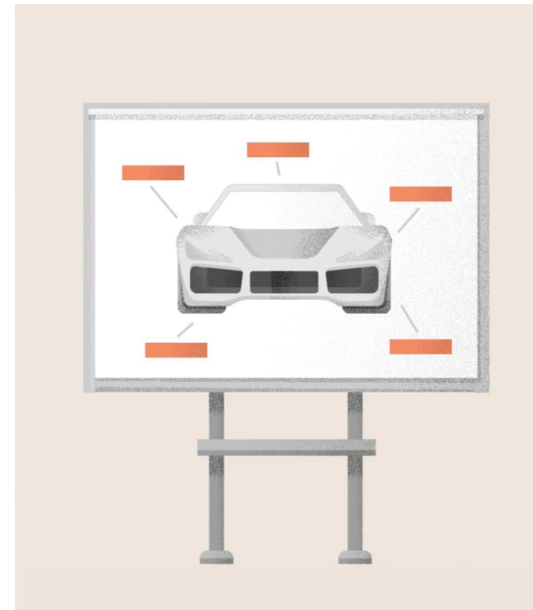
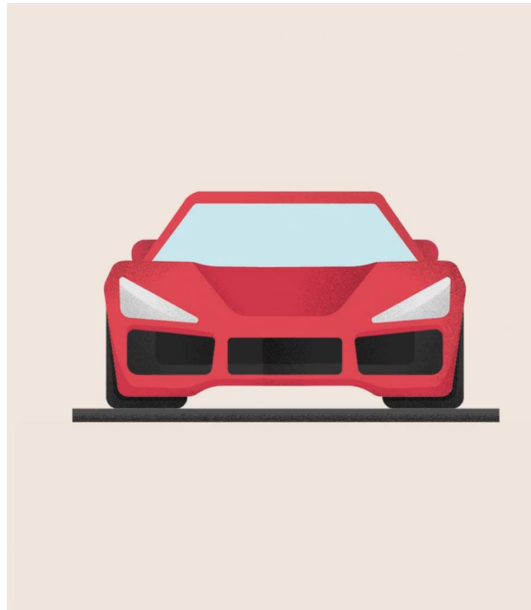
A project could well be one of many undertaken in any particular time-frame. Sometimes these projects can form a cycle. For example, one project team may hone a strategy that other project teams will be tasked with implementing.

In other cases, the projects are more self-contained. Even with such projects however, it's important to overlap the completion of one project and the start of a new one.



Projects in Cycles and in Isolation (cont.)

A good example comes from car manufacturing. Every few years most major manufacturers introduce an updated or totally new model. Clearly, the project to design the new version will have been underway well before the previous model ceased production. Otherwise, there would be a gap of several years, with no product for sale at all, between each version. A project manager needs to be aware of how their project fits with other, related, projects within the organisation.





Recap

In this lesson, you have learned about the lifecycle of a project, and its **five key phases**.

- Conception and Initiation
- Definition and Planning
- Execution
- Performance and Monitoring
- Closure

As well as

- How the project fits with other, related, projects within the organisation.